

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

WHAT'S NEXT FOR BLAGOJEVICH?

Pardoned ex-governor looks to write book, offers no apologies

By Rick Pearson and Jeremy Gornor
Chicago Tribune

Perhaps the most telling moment of the news conference Rod Blagojevich held hours after President Donald Trump granted the disgraced ex-Illinois governor a full pardon came even before he answered a single question from the media scrum

gathered outside his Ravenswood Manor home. “Patti, honey,” Blagojevich said with a smile to his wife Monday night. “They’re back.” The comment reflected one of Blagojevich’s most prominent and defining traits — witnessed at campaign rallies, during his time in office and later in countless TV appearances in which he declared his innocence — that of a cockalorum, a boastful and self-important person in need of public attention and adoration.

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Former Illinois Gov. Rod Blagojevich walks outside his Ravenswood Manor home after he was granted a full pardon by President Donald Trump on Monday. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Invasive carp project delayed

Pritzker cites concerns about promised federal funding being withheld

By Adriana Pérez
Chicago Tribune

Anticipating a lack of federal funding under the new presidential administration, Illinois has postponed construction on a long-awaited \$1.15 billion project to stop the movement of invasive carp up Illinois waterways and into Lake Michigan. A groundbreaking ceremony scheduled for Tuesday was canceled. Should the fish reach the Great Lakes, they would pose a significant threat to the region’s native species and aquatic ecosystems as well as its billion-dollar fishing and boating industries. The project at Brandon Road Lock and Dam near Joliet is part of a decades-long infrastructure effort between Illinois, Michigan and the federal government to deter the upstream movement of silver and bighead carp.

While \$340 million has already been allocated for phase one of the project, officials are worried about going any further without assurances from President Donald Trump’s administration that funding critical for the next two phases won’t be held back.

According to Illinois Gov. JB Pritzker, Trump’s administration continues to withhold \$117 million in federal grants from the Bipartisan Infrastructure Law that is supposed to go to the Illinois Department of Natural Resources, halting 70 unrelated projects across the state. Because of the uncertainty about funding for these projects, Pritzker and IDNR Director Natalie Phelps Finnie have expressed concerns about starting construction at Brandon Road.

In a letter Monday to the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers, the project’s lead federal partner, Phelps

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Anthony Hyde, son of the late U.S. Rep. Henry Hyde, takes a last look at the DuPage County Board after reading a statement in support of keeping his father’s name on the Henry J. Hyde Judicial Office Facility during a county board meeting on Tuesday in Wheaton. **STACEY WESCOTT/TRIBUNE**

DuPage County Board strips Hyde’s name from courthouse

Latest indicator Democrats have taken over the once-Republican stronghold

By Tess Kenny
Naperville Sun

The DuPage County courthouse will no longer bear the name of the late U.S. Rep. Henry Hyde, the latest indicator that a Democratic blue wave has washed over the once Republican stronghold in recent years.

The Democrat-controlled DuPage County Board voted 10-5 at its Tuesday meeting to remove the Republican congressman’s name from the building and related offices in Wheaton.



Rep. Henry Hyde in 1998.

While two parties voted along partisan lines, Democrats Lynn LaPlante, of Glen Ellyn, and Lucy Chang Evans, of Naperville, abstained from the vote and expressed disappointment that the matter was raised.

The courthouse will now be known as the DuPage County Judicial Office Facility.

“Here in DuPage County, public buildings serve all people, regardless of race, gender, faith or ... economic status,” board Chair Deb Conroy, a Democrat from

Elmhurst, said ahead the vote. “This resolution reinforces the notion that the buildings on this campus support the rights of all people to receive the services they need. I believe our actions should reflect our values.”

Hyde, a Wood Dale Republican and staunch abortion opponent, is the namesake of the Hyde Amendment, a law that took effect in 1980 banning the use of federal funds to pay for abortion in all cases other than rape, incest or to save the life of the woman giving birth.

The board’s resolution Tuesday was in “direct response to

women who were marginalized (by) or reminded” of the Hyde Amendment “when they walked into the courthouse,” Conroy said.

Hyde represented parts of DuPage County in the House of Representatives from 1975 until 2007 and in the Illinois House for nearly a decade prior to that.

He died in 2007 at age 83. Three years after his death, the DuPage County Board — then a firmly entrenched Republican stronghold — voted to name its courthouse building in Wheaton

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6 accused of kidnapping, forced transfer of crypto

3 family members forced to move about \$15M in assets

By Rebecca Johnson
Chicago Tribune

Six men are accused of kidnapping three family members and a nanny from a Chicago townhouse in October and forcing a transfer of about \$15 million in crypto-

currency assets before releasing them four days later near a dry cleaners, according to recently unsealed court records.

The five-day kidnapping is detailed in a 44-page FBI affidavit unsealed last week. Agents collected evidence — including receipts, unused zip ties and surveillance footage — from rental cars, cryptocurrency wallets, a suburban Airbnb and various fast-food restaurants

and retail stores, court records show.

One of the alleged kidnappers, 34-year-old Zehuan Wei, was arrested Jan. 17 while trying to enter the United States from Mexico at a California border crossing. He made an initial court appearance in California.

Five other men are charged with kidnapping in the case: Fan Zhang, Huajing Yan, Shengnan Jiang, Shiqiang Lian and Ye Cao.

Some of them are believed to have taken flights from Mexico to China last month after Wei’s arrest, according to an FBI search warrant affidavit.

The court records do not say where the suspects are from but indicated that some held U.S. drivers licenses. At least Zhang and Wei also had Chinese passports, documents show.

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CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Bulls’ glut of guards poses challenge

The team now has nine guards. Coach Billy Donovan will have to balance playing time with development. **Chicago Sports**

Netanyahu threatens resumption of war

The Israeli leader on Tuesday said the Gaza truce will end if Hamas does not release more hostages on Saturday. **Nation & World**

TODAY'S WEATHER



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Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 16

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